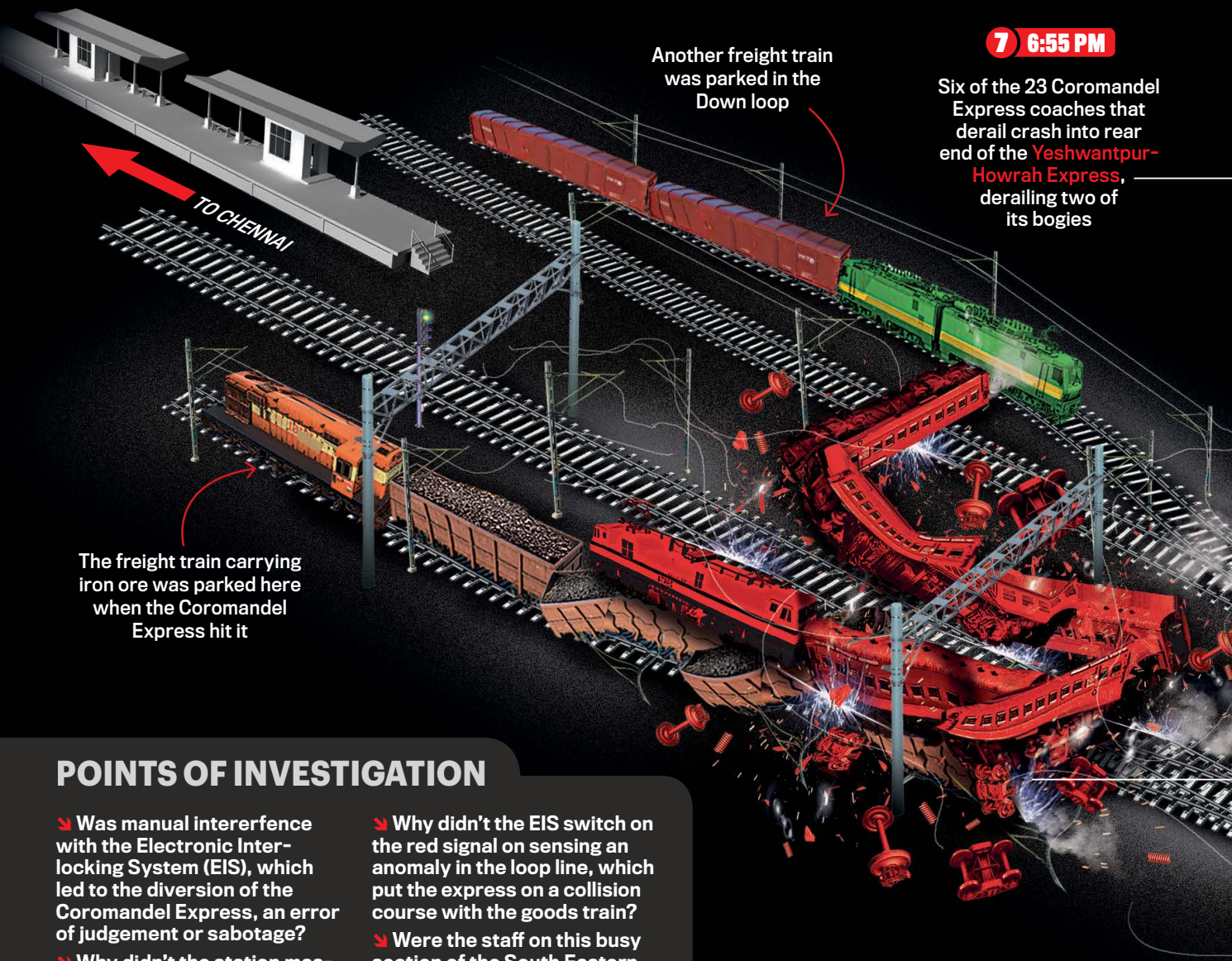


POINTS OF INVESTIGATION

- Was manual intererfence with the Electronic Interlocking System (EIS), which led to the diversion of the Coromandel Express, an error of judgement or sabotage?
- Why didn't the station master and signal inspector carry out the mandatory physical checks to ensure the EIS was functioning normally?
- Why didn't the EIS switch on the red signal on sensing an anomaly in the loop line, which put the express on a collision course with the goods train?
- Were the staff on this busy section of the South Eastern Railway sector overstressed and under pressure to push through trains to avoid delays?

UNDER THE SCANNER

Station Master Tasked with enforcing compliance with rules, discharge of staff duties

- Inspects all signals, level crossing gates and station machinery. Promptly reports defects
- Sole authority to give the 'line clear' for trains to proceed

Sectional Signal Inspector Monitors staff that adjust the signalling gears, and the electrical signal maintainers who carry out maintenance work

Electrical Signal Maintainers Entrusted with upkeep of railways signalling installations and maintenance of block instruments, panels, points and crossings and other repairs

Permanent Way Inspector Maintenance and inspection of tracks to ensure they are safe for traffic; track relaying works

Electronic Interlocking System A fully software-driven installation that sets the routes for trains

- It helps save time, ensures safety and facilitates easier diagnosis in case of failures

THE FATAL TIMELINE



1 4:35 PM

- Station manager (SM) gives sectional signal inspector (SSI) the go-ahead to replace the boom barrier at a nearby level crossing with the latest electric lifting barrier
- Issues a disconnect memo for the SSI to decouple the Signal Interlocking System (SIS) from the barrier, allowing repairs without affecting train movement



2 4:36 PM

The SSI disconnects the interlocking system, begins work with a couple of electrical signal maintainers and gang workers